

GALACTIC PRIME TIME

Game Design Document

Lights. Camera. Action.

Version 0.2 // Draft // Confidential

Genre	2.5D Tactical RPG — Turn-Based Clock Combat / Open World Exploration
Engine	Godot
Platform	PC (Primary)
Target Length	40+ hours. New Game Plus with Ascension system.
Tone	Dark corporate satire. LitRPG spectacle. Nobody becoming somebody.
References	Salt & Sanctuary, Dark Souls, Heroes of Might & Magic, Songs of Conquest, Darkest Dungeon

1. Vision & Concept

Galactic Prime Time is a 2.5D tactical RPG set inside an intergalactic reality TV show. Players build a custom party of abducted human contestants and fight through a handcrafted dungeon broadcast live to an alien audience. The core fantasy is the underdog arc — nobody becomes somebody under the worst possible conditions, while the galaxy watches.

Core Pillars

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| • Spectacle over safety | • Nobody to somebody arc |
| • Identity through Tags | • Timeline combat |
| • The Audience as an active mechanic | • Every run shapes the next |

Tone References

Dungeon Crawler Carl · The Running Man · LitRPG genre · MMO design sensibility

2. Core Game Loop

A single session loop:

- Explore the dungeon — navigate hex-based environments, encounter NPCs, discover routes.
- Engage — choose sub-dungeons, face encounters, manage the Clock.
- Combat — deploy party, manage Moments, apply conditions, survive.
- Boss — each floor culminates in a Boss encounter with unique win conditions.
- Return to the Lounge — craft, upgrade, open Loot Boxes, prepare next run.

The broadcast frames everything. The audience reacts in real time. Viewers, Followers, and Patrons respond to every decision.

3. Narrative Delivery

Story is delivered across three layers, each serving a distinct purpose:

Broadcast Layer

Major story beats are delivered as show segments — cutscenes framed as TV broadcasts. The announcer narrates, the camera lingers, the audience reacts. Used for floor transitions, boss introductions, and Ascension moments. Also serves as the hint system — the broadcast frames clues in corporate PR language.

Dialogue Layer

NPC interactions deliver story transparently through direct conversation. Characters speak plainly about their situation, motivations, and history. This is where route-specific arcs live — the man with the mask, the demon girl, the Loong.

Environmental Layer

Hidden lore lives in the world itself. Murals, item descriptions, corpse placement, and architecture tell the deeper story of the dungeon and the Corporation. Rewards attentive players without blocking casual ones.

4. Combat System

Clock-Based Timeline

Combat runs on a shared 10-Moment Clock counting downward. All combatants act on the same timeline — actions are declared, costs are tallied, and resolution overlaps. There are no turns. There is only pressure.

Key Combat Rules

- Actions auto-succeed when stat requirements are met — no to-hit rolls.
- Multi-Moment actions leave the character Exposed for their duration.
- Forced Action (d6 Body or Tool table) resolves dangerous or impaired actions.
- Localized HP — each body part has individual HP and failure states.
- Conditions escalate per Clock: Bleeding, Crushed, Suffocation, Chilled, Exhausted, Infected, Burn, Poison, Dissolution.

Party Deployment

The active party size is capped by the number of hex spaces on the battlefield. Players choose which characters to deploy at the start of combat. Additional characters can be deployed mid-combat for a Moment cost.

Unit Types

Characters	Individual named units. Full skill, condition, and localized HP system applies.
Stacks	Groups of unnamed units (e.g. villagers with pitchforks). Simplified HP pool. Retreat or collapse as a group.

Retrieval

Units not within an enemy's current attack range can be retrieved to the bench mid-combat. Units inside attack range cannot be retrieved — or lose forces attempting it (Stacks). An exhaustion system discourages constant zerg deployment: deployed units accumulate Exhaustion, benched units recover.

5. Party & Progression

Races

Players choose from three starter races: Human, Animal, or Robot. Each race has distinct body part configurations, starter skills, and racial traits. Race changes are available mid-campaign via the Surgeon's Table or Augmentation Hub in the Lounge.

Race Unlocks

Winning a run permanently unlocks the winning character's race as a starter option in all future runs. Characters who switched races during a run unlock all races they inhabited. As more races are unlocked, multi-race worlds become available — the Corporation pulls mixed-species contestant groups from planets where multiple races coexist.

Skills & Tags

Skills are leveled, with thresholds triggering upgrades or mutations at every level from 5 onward. Tags represent the Show's identity label for a character — earned through behavior, fulfilled conditions, or completed Goals. Tags influence loot bias, crowd response, and mechanical triggers.

Exposure System

Viewers	Active watchers. Drive hype momentum and reward potential.
Followers	Recurring audience. Stabilize the reward floor and influence directive frequency.
Patrons	Paying supporters. Set Goals for rewards. Each new Patron awards a Patron Token.
Patron Tokens	Spent to raise a skill's cap beyond 5, up to a ceiling of 10.

6. World Structure

Floor Layout

The dungeon is divided into three floors, each with three route options (Easy / Medium / Hard). Players choose one route per floor — others play out offscreen and affect the world state.

Floor 1	Green forest. Tutorial difficulty. Three branching routes introduced.
Floor 2	Great desert. Same routes, 70 years later. Consequences of Floor 1 visible.
Floor 3	Grand capital city. 100 years after Floor 2. Routes converge toward the finale.

Checkpoints

Checkpoints are sparse — Elden Ring density. They function as rewind points: death resets world state to the last checkpoint. Character upgrades and Lounge improvements persist. Checkpoints are milestones, not safety nets.

The Lounge

The party's modular base of operations. Unlocked after the tutorial boss. Fully monitored by the Corporation — every upgrade increases surveillance. Contains Living Facilities, Factory, Modification Center, Garage, and Universal Travel.

7. New Game Plus & Ascension

Ascension

At any point after reaching a progression threshold (completing Floor 1), a player may Ascend a character. Ascending retires the character from active play and converts them into a Patron. The player starts a fresh character, backed by their Ascended character's existing audience.

Becoming a Patron

There are two ways a character enters the Patron pool:

- Corporate Ascension — mid-run retirement via deal with the Corporation. Patron Goals reflect corporate interests: efficiency, spectacle, profit.
- Winner's Arc — completing the show and returning home. The character rejoins galactic society as a viewer-turned-Patron. Goals reflect personal history and Tag legacy.

Death is permanent. A character who dies cannot become a Patron.

Patron Budget

A Patron's spending budget in NG+ is derived from their popularity at the time of Ascension or victory. Viewers contribute a base budget. Followers multiply it. Patrons add a significant bonus. Exact conversion rates are a balancing variable.

Tags as Goal Modifiers

A Patron's Tag history becomes mechanical weight on the Goals they set. A Patron with Vengeful in their history sets revenge-type Goals with higher payouts. Tragic Goals carry higher risk and bigger reward. The Tag shapes the Goal's flavor and economy, not the Patron's personality.

Goal Rejection

Players can ignore Patron Goals. Consistently ignored Patrons lose credibility and budget over time — their audience drifts. This mirrors real patronage dynamics without requiring a firing mechanic.

Multiple Patrons

Multiple Ascended characters can back the same run simultaneously. Conflicting Goals from different Patrons create organic drama. A veteran player may have several old characters all competing for their current character's attention.

8. Data Architecture

The game runs fully offline with no external dependencies. Data is split between two storage layers based on mutability.

Static Data — SQLite

All read-only game data lives in a SQLite database bundled with the game. SQLite runs embedded — no server process, no setup, no internet required. On first launch the game seeds the database from flat source files. This layer is never written to at runtime.

Static data includes:

- Skills — stat requirements, levels, thresholds, upgrade/mutation definitions
- Items & weapons — damage values, modifier slots, tier, requirements
- Conditions — advancement tiers, effects, spread rules
- Races — body part configurations, starter skills, racial traits
- Tags — unlock conditions, Goal modifier weights
- Enemies — stat blocks, phase definitions, behavior tables

Dynamic Data — JSON Save Files

All data that changes during play is serialized to JSON files. Two categories of save file exist with different persistence rules.

Run State	Active floor, party state, Lounge upgrades, Clock position, checkpoint snapshot. Written on every checkpoint. Restored on death. Wiped on run end.
Persistent State	Unlocked races, Patron pool, Ascended characters, NG+ progress, Tag history. Never wiped. Survives across all runs and deaths.

Combat Simulation Layer

Combat logic runs as a headless simulation layer entirely separate from the Godot scene tree. The simulation is pure logic classes with no rendering dependencies — the scene tree is presentation only, listening to simulation events and rendering results. This separation makes checkpoint serialization trivial, enables headless testing, and allows future replay systems.

Model	Headless simulation — Clock queue, combatant state, condition advancement, action resolution.
View	Godot scene tree — hex grid, animations, UI, audience reactions.
Controller	Thin layer translating player input into simulation commands and simulation events into visual cues.

Design Principle

The data access layer must abstract storage backend from game logic. Static data queries go through a single service interface — if SQLite is ever swapped for another backend, no game logic changes.

9. Open Design Questions

The following require resolution before full implementation:

Patron budget formula	Exact Viewer/Follower/Patron conversion rates to NG+ spending budget.
Ascension threshold	Floor 1 completion proposed — confirm before implementation.
NG+ modifiers	Does the world change beyond the Patron system? Escalating difficulty TBD.
Exhaustion rates	Deployment exhaustion accumulation and bench recovery rates need balancing.
Stack mechanics	Full rules for Stack HP pools, collapse conditions, and morale not yet defined.
Narrative delivery	Broadcast cutscene format and announcer voice direction not yet specified.

10. Scope & Risks

Primary Risks

- Clock combat visual clarity — hex grid engagement ranges must be readable at a glance.
- Forced Action digitization — d6 GM-adjudicated consequences need deterministic rulesets for each outcome.
- Narrative Token rebuild — 'GM discretion' scope requires complete mechanical redesign for digital context.
- Solo build scope — architecture, encounter design, and asset pipeline are significant for one developer.

Strengths

- Clock combat is genuinely novel and video game-ready.
- Broadcast framing is a strong differentiator — no current game owns this space.
- Ascension / Patron system creates long-term replayability without live service.
- Race unlock system gives veteran players a sense of world-building across runs.
- Developer has full-stack professional experience — technical risk is low.